

Urban Agglomeration Theory
-Jaffna-

Assessment 06

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Origin of Jaffna Town

Jaffna has a very deep history which has been proven and documented by many historians, archeologists, and researchers. The origin and history of Jaffna are intertwined with the broader historical of the region.

I. Early settlements and Kingdoms

The Jaffna region has a rich history dating back thousands of years. Archaeological evidence suggests that the region was inhabited in prehistoric times. An ancient chronicle known as the Mahavamsa documenting the history of Sri Lanka dates back to BC. It mentions the existence of a Tamil kingdom in the Jaffna region in the 2nd century.

Jaffna played a significant role in the ancient Tamil kingdoms of Sri Lanka. The region was ruled by various Tamil dynasties, including the Chola dynasty from South India, who exerted their influence over the region at different periods. Tamil rulers created a distinct culture and society in Jaffna, establishing Hindu temples, irrigation systems, and trade networks. These historical events mentioned in the Indian Tamil books like, Silappathiharam, Manimekhalai. Jaffna was ruled by Aryan emperors since the 13th century. Mahavamsa, Yalppanavaipavamaalai (very ancient Tamil book), Kailaajamaalai mention this ruling history very clearly. Now also ruins of Jaffna kingdom scattered throughout the city can be seen very clearly.

II. Colonial Era

Jaffna came under European influence during the colonial period. The Portuguese came to the region in the 16th century and took over the region from the last king Sangiliyan. After that they took control of Jaffna along with other parts of Sri Lanka. They referred to Jaffna as "Jafanapatão" and documented its strategic and economic importance. However, their rule was short-lived as the Dutch drove out the Portuguese and conquered Jaffna in the 17th century. The Dutch influence can still be seen in the architecture of some buildings in Jaffna today. Dutch Fort is a great example of that. Additionally, churches, schools and Kachcheri buildings also can be seen here.



Figure 1 Jaffna Dutch fort

III. British rule and post-Independence

The British took over Jaffna from the Dutch in the late 18th century and incorporated it into British Ceylon. Under British rule, Jaffna saw the introduction of modern administrative systems, infrastructure development and education. After that, the city became a center of Tamil education and cultural revival. The British Empire developed their culture and religious activities on the coastal fringes of the city. The British empire promoted Jaffna as the capital of the northern part of Sri Lanka.

IV. After Independence (1948)

Following Sri Lanka's independence from British rule in 1948, Jaffna remained an important cultural, educational, and economic hub for the Tamil population. However, tensions between the Tamil minority and the government in Sri Lanka eventually escalated into a civil war that lasted from 1983 to 2009. Jaffna and the surrounding areas were heavily affected by the conflict, with significant damage to infrastructure and displacement of residents. Jaffna has gone through a phase of post-war reconstruction and development since the end of the civil war.

V. Current Situation of Jaffna town

Infrastructural reconstruction, cultural heritage site restoration, economic development promotion and inter-ethnic reconciliation efforts are all underway in the city. Today, Jaffna city is a major commercial and administrative city in the Northern Province. It has a lot of infrastructural facilities and administration. The city of Jaffna serves as the main commercial center of the Northern Province.

Origin of Jaffna town transformed through, Early settlements , ancient kingdoms, Colonial Era (Portuguese – Dutch – British), After independence to current situation. The above clarifications clearly describe the origin and formation of Jaffna town.

Mobility of Jaffna town based on 'Factors of non-agricultural production activities'

Factors of non-agricultural production activities refer to the resources and elements necessary for economic production in sectors other than agriculture. These factors include labor, capital, entrepreneurship, and infrastructure.

Textile and garment manufacturing, construction, traditional handicraft making, Food processing, IT services, Printing and Publishing, Brick and tile manufacturing, fishing and sea food processing are the common industrial activities happen in and around the Jaffna town to contribute to the local economy.

I. Skilled labor

The presence and mobility of labor allowed the town of Jaffna to grow. For example, skilled workers from other regions specializing in various fields migrated to Jaffna. Their movement helped establish industries such as textiles, construction, printing, Handicraft, and manufacturing, created jobs and contributed to the town's local economic growth.

II. Capital

The movement of capital facilitated investment in the town of Jaffna. Local and foreign investors recognized the city's potential and poured financial resources into businesses and infrastructure. For example, the establishment of commercial banks and financial institutions allowed capital inflows to support the growth of industries, trade, hire labor, and urban infrastructure development.

III. Entrepreneurship

Entrepreneurship is a critical factor in driving economic activities and shaping urban centers. Entrepreneurs identified opportunities and took risks to establish businesses. One notable example can be observed in recent days is the growth of the information technology (IT) sector in Jaffna. Young entrepreneurs started IT companies, offering software development, outsourcing, and IT-enabled services. This entrepreneurial mobility led to the town becoming a hub for IT-related activities and contributes to Jaffna's local economy.

IV. Raw materials

The town's location facilitated trade links with neighboring regions and international markets. The mobility of goods and services through trade is an important factor in the town's formation. For example, the coastal areas of the Jaffna Peninsula have facilitated the development of fishing and seafood processing industries, promoting economic growth and trade opportunities.

Economies of Scale Supported the Urban functions of the Jaffna Town

Increasing the scale of production results in cost savings and efficiency gains known as economies of scale. When the volume of production increases, the average cost per production decreases can observed in this concept. Economies of scale play a crucial role in shaping development strategies and decisions. These economies of scale have contributed to Jaffna towns urban development and functioning in various ways. Several urban functions can be observed in Jaffna region. Economies of scale supporting these urban functions of Jaffna town.

Economies of scale have made it possible for Jaffna Town to effectively deliver necessary services to its expanding population in terms of infrastructure development. Large-scale infrastructure projects, such as road networks and water supply systems, have been implemented, benefiting from the cost savings achieved through spreading fixed costs over a larger user base. By spreading the fixed costs of construction and maintenance over a larger population, the average cost per user decreases, making it more cost-effective to provide services. This has ensured better accessibility, improved connectivity, and more efficient service delivery. Economies of scale have supported the provision of public services in Jaffna Town. By centralizing services such as education and healthcare, the town has been able to optimize resource allocation and achieve cost efficiencies. A notable example is the establishment of a large, well-equipped hospital that offers specialized medical services to a larger population. This consolidation of resources has improved the quality and accessibility of public services while minimizing costs per user.

Economies of scale have contributed to the growth of Jaffna town's economic activities in terms of industrial and commercial development. By concentrating industries in specific industrial zones, businesses benefit from shared infrastructure, utilities, and access to transportation. It has attracted investments, encouraged job creation, and spurred economic growth. Large-scale industrial complexes and business centers, such as the Atchuvely Industrial Zone, have been established to provide cost efficiency through distributed resources and services. Jaffna town is the main trade center in the northern province. This factor also plays a major role in obtaining more customers.

These development activities, health care facilities, availability of market, high transportation networks connect other cities to Jaffna town with reduced transportation costs. Concentration of resources, infrastructure and services has allowed for cost efficiency, improved service delivery and sustainable urban development. By leveraging economies of scale, the town of Jaffna has been able to grow and function as a vibrant urban center, meeting the needs of its growing population and supporting various aspects of urban life.

Externalities of Developments in Jaffna town

Externalities of developments refer to the unintended and often unaccounted for effects that arise from economic activities. These effects can be positive or negative and impacts on the town's economy and its functions. These externalities played a role in accumulating more economic activities and shaping the concept of Jaffna Town.

The developments in Jaffna Town created numerous employment opportunities, reducing unemployment rates, and providing income sources for the local population. New businesses, industries, and services generated jobs across various sectors, contributing to economic growth and improving livelihoods. The economic activities accumulated in Jaffna Town resulted in increased tax revenue for the local government. As businesses flourished and incomes rose, tax revenues from various sources, such as property taxes and business taxes, grew. This additional revenue can be used to invest in infrastructure, public services, and community development.

The developments in Jaffna Town led to improved infrastructure to support the growing economic activities. This includes the expansion of roads, transportation networks, utilities, and public facilities. The improved infrastructure not only benefits businesses but also enhances the quality of life for residents and tourists. The accumulation of economic activities in Jaffna Town facilitated knowledge and skill development. As industries and businesses established themselves, they brought new technologies, expertise, and best practices. This knowledge and skill transfer provided opportunities for local workers to acquire new skills, improve their employability, and foster innovation within the region.

At the same time, the increase in economic activities resulted in higher levels of traffic in Jaffna Town. This led to traffic congestion, increased travel times, and decreased overall transportation efficiency, resulting in negative externalities such as increased air pollution and reduced quality of life for residents. The rapid urbanization and increased economic activities in Jaffna Town may have caused environmental degradation. This includes issues like pollution, deforestation, and depletion of natural resources. For example, industrial activities might have led to increased pollution levels in air and water bodies, impacting the local environment and public health. The accumulation of economic activities in Jaffna Town could have contributed to rising housing prices. As demand for housing increased due to a growing population and the influx of workers, the limited supply of housing led to higher costs, making it more challenging for certain segments of the population to afford housing.

Overall, the externalities resulting from the developments in Jaffna Town, such as agglomeration effects, employment opportunities, infrastructure development, service expansion, knowledge transfer, and market expansion, played a significant role in accumulating more economic activities and shaping the concept of Jaffna Town as a thriving economic center.